Import Maps

I mentioned in passing at the beginning of the book that the jsbunding and cssbundling tooling is not the default in Rails 7. The Rails 7 default is called importmaps-rails, and is based on a newish standard feature called Import Maps. The goal of Import Maps is to allow you to write JavaScript tooling without doing any build step or bundling at all, and without having to use Node.js at all.

Import maps have the promise of a developer environment that is not encumbered by a continual JavaScript build process, and as such, sound pretty great. Import Maps are especially useful for Rails projects that don't have a tremendous number of dependent packages, and don't do much in the way of transpiling or converting assets.

Because import map based tooling does not include asset conversion, it's difficult for me to use our current project as an example of how importmap-rails works. Our sample project does a lot of transpiling, both TypeScript and JSX, meaning that as our project is currently set up, it's not a good candidate for Import Maps. (To show how Import Maps would work in our project, we'd need to take it all the way back to bare bones and reinstall and not use TypeScript, which would be pretty confusing.) So, in this section, we'll look at the basics of how Import Maps would be used in a typical Rails project. Later, in Appendix 1, *Framework Swap*, I will tear the project down and build it back up, and you can look there to see what this all looks like in more code detail.

At this point, you might be wondering "what the heck is an import map?"

Import Maps are a different way of thinking about sending JavaScript to the browser by allowing the browser to directly convert a JavaScript import statement to the URL of a file to fetch from the browser to resolve that import.

If I can oversimplify, esbuild, webpack, and other bundling tools allow you to reference other files or external modules within your code because they resolve all the references at packaging time, and send a single file to the browser with all